

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

GOP split on budget details

Senate homes in on deportations; House seeks \$4T in tax cuts

By Lisa Mascaro and Kevin Freking
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — As House Republicans missed another deadline Friday to produce a massive budget package of tax cuts and slashed spending, Senate Republicans jumped ahead, unveiling a more tailored \$340 billion blueprint focused on President Donald Trump's deportation agenda and bolstered U.S. defense spending.

Speaker Mike Johnson acknowledged that his own chamber's plan for Trump's budget bill would slip into the weekend as his party works overtime to agree to the details. After a lengthy meeting a day earlier with the Republican president at the White House, they are racing to hammer out a package that includes about \$4 trillion in tax breaks, massive program cuts and a possible extension of the nation's debt limit.

"We have just a few final details to iron out," Johnson said at the Capitol. "It's going well, and I'm very excited about where we are and

Turn to Budget, Page 6

NATION & WORLD Judge halts forced leaves at USAID

A federal judge on Friday temporarily blocked the Trump administration from placing 2,200 employees of the U.S. Agency for International Development on paid leave.

■ Democrats, citing threats to national and private security, want DOGE's access to the Treasury investigated.

A Chicagoan's journey through incarceration, deportation and his family's role in building the most comprehensive guidebook for noncitizens under increasing threat



'A NEW PATH'

By Nell Salzman
Chicago Tribune

Erick vividly remembers stepping off a plane at the Texas-Mexico border, shackled, when he was deported in 2013.

The group he was with was marched single-file across the border to Matamoros, Mexico, to a bus terminal, which he said was just sandbags and barbed wire.

Though Erick was familiar with gangs in Chicago, he said he had no familiarity with what group violence looked like in Matamoros.

"It's worse," he said. "You know how to navigate that world, as opposed to here, you have no idea what to expect."

Erick was brought to the United States from Mexico at 4 months old. He was deported 33 years later, after being imprisoned for 15 years for a first-degree murder he says he didn't commit. Without knowledge of the judicial system, he pleaded guilty to murder because his attorney told



Top: Maria and Joaquin talk about their son, Erick, who was deported years ago, while surrounded by some of his artwork at their home in Little Village on Jan. 28. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Above: Lee Ragsdale and her husband, Erick, in Grenada in an undated photo. **LEE RAGSDALE**

him he thought it would shorten the length of his sentence.

Upon request, his last name is being withheld by the Tribune to maintain privacy.

His wife, Lee Ragsdale, was familiar with the travails of formerly incarcerated people due to her work for the Education Justice Project, a unit of the College of Education at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign that produced guides to help with reentry. She began working for the project in 2010, and after watching her husband deal with the unknowns of deportation, she advocated for a similar resource specifically for noncitizens navigating a different type of entry into a new country.

Published by an EJP team in 2018, the guide, called "A New Path: A Guide to the Challenges and Opportunities After Deportation," provides tips not just for

Turn to Path, Page 4



A CTA Pink Line train departs the Ashland station on Nov. 10, 2022. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

United Center redevelopment plan could come with Pink Line station

By Sarah Freishtat
Chicago Tribune

By the time the United Center opened in 1994, an "L" station that was once about a block away from the stadium had been gone for decades.

There were brief talks of restoring the station for the 1996 Democratic National Convention, but those plans never materialized. Later, in 2006, the CTA's Pink Line opened on a stretch of

old track alongside United Center parking lots, with no new stop at Madison Street.

But the time might soon arrive for a new Pink Line stop at Madison, as plans progress on a proposal by the owners of the Bulls and Blackhawks to redevelop the neighborhood around the United Center. A new station has the support of the developers and the local alderman, and CTA and city officials have begun early discussions about the feasibility

of a new "L" stop.

Building a new station won't be without challenges. It would likely take years, and wasn't included among plans to privately finance the first phase of the development, which includes construction of a new music hall, hotel and green space in the area. Ald. Walter Burnett, whose 27th Ward includes the neighborhood, raised the possibility of exploring

Turn to Station, Page 4

Banks fighting state's credit card fees law

In court and at Capitol, companies say they're not equipped to handle interchange fees ban

By Olivia Olander
Chicago Tribune

Financial services companies in Illinois are fighting a landmark state law on credit card fees in court and in Springfield as banks get closer to a July 1 implementation they say they're not equipped to meet.

"The rails are not built for this train to move on. Like, they are not constructed. They don't even know — the engineering part is not done yet, let alone tracks laid down," Ben Jackson, executive vice president of government relations at the Illinois Bankers Association, said after a downtown status hearing on the lawsuit Thursday.

The first-of-its-kind law, signed by Gov. JB Pritzker after being passed by Illinois lawmakers last year, will ban banks and credit card companies from charging retailers a small fee on sales taxes and tips. Retailers who support the measure say

they're advocating for consumers while banks claim the law could create chaos in transactions that will inconvenience businesses and their customers.

Financial companies scored a partial victory in court when a federal judge in December agreed to put a temporary hold on the law for some types of institutions including national banks, meaning that they don't need to comply with the law as court proceedings continue. That relief was expanded this week to out-of-state banks doing business in Illinois, but other entities including payment networks, federal credit unions and in-state banks remain subject to the law.

The IBA as well as the American Bankers Association, America's Credit Unions and the Illinois Credit Union League are plaintiffs in the suit, which names Illinois Attorney General Kwame Raoul as a defendant.

Turn to Banks, Page 2

TODAY'S WEATHER High 33 Low 21

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 8

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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